

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called "The Twelve Buddhas"

Ārya-dvādaśabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 853 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བའི་ཐུགས་ཀྱི་འཕགས་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called "The Twelve Buddhas" (Sanskrit: Āryadvādaśabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra; Tibetan: 'Phags pa sangs rgyas bcu gnyis pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo) is a short Mahāyāna sūtra concerned with twelve buddhas and the benefits of hearing and remembering their names. It is set at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak, where the Buddha addresses the bodhisattva Maitreya and begins describing a buddha dwelling in a distant world-realm called Mukṭikā, Pearl-Possessing, to the east of our own. Texts of this kind belong to a familiar current of Mahāyāna literature in which the names and buddha-fields of particular buddhas are taught as objects of devotion, recollection, and protection. In the canon it is Toh 853 in the Kangyur, the collection of translated words of the Buddha, where it is classed among the sūtras.

In the language of India: Ārya-dvādaśabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called "The Twelve Buddhas." Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great assembly of monks, twelve hundred and fifty monks, and likewise together with a great assembly of bodhisattvas, twenty thousand bodhisattvas, headed by the bodhisattva Aparājita and others.

Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya: "Maitreya, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond buddha-fields as numerous as the atoms in ten ineffable hundred-thousand-millions of buddha-fields, there is a world-realm called Mukṭikā, Pearl-Possessing. There dwells the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha, Gaganaśrī-vimala-rajohara-suru cira-guṇaketu-prabha-puṣpa-padma-vaiḍūrya-raśmi-ratnarūpa, whose body is like a jewel and who is honored with the finest incense. His body is exquisitely adorned and beautified, and from the crown of his head, the uṣṇīṣa, countless rays like the sun's pour forth. He is adorned with the moonlight of his aspirations and with vast, magnificent emanations. Manifestly arisen from the dharmadhātu, he is the noble one called Unattached King of Jewels. Even now he abides there, living and sustained, and he teaches the Dharma.

Whoever holds the name of that Victor will turn back from saṃsāra for as many eons as there are atoms in the great continent of Jambudvīpa, over great eons.

That Victor prophesied about the bodhisattva, the great being called Peerless: Immediately after that Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha, the one described above, passes into nirvāṇa and his sacred Dharma has disappeared, Peerless will manifestly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He will appear in the world as a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide of beings to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One, called Jaladeva-kumāra-sūrya-pradīpa-candra-puṣpa-padma-suvarṇa-darśana-gaganasadrśakāya, Vairocana, Raśmivyūha, Aśaṅgacakra-maṇḍala, he who radiates light in the ten directions, Sarvalokadhātu-avabhāsakara-ketu-dhvaja-rāja.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha of that same eastern direction, Sarvavyūha-vimala-prabha, Light of All Adornments, Free from Stain. One should recite the words. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha of the southern direction, Pratibhānavyūha-adhyāśaya, He Who Contemplates the Adornment of Eloquence. One should reflect on it.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the western direction, Vimala-candraketu-rāja, Famous King, Banner of the Stainless Moon. One should pay homage."

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the northern direction, Pushpavyūha-prabhāsa, He Who Illumines the Adornment of Flowers. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the southeastern intermediate direction, Prabhākara, the Maker of Light. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the southwestern intermediate direction, Ratnottama-ketu-yaśasvin, Renowned Crest of the Supreme Jewel. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the northwestern intermediate direction, Abhaya-vikrānta, Fearless Beholder. One should pay

homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the northeastern intermediate direction, He Who Is Free from Fear, Without Anxiety, Whose Hair Does Not Stand on End. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the nadir, Siṃha-vijrmbhita, He Who Stretches Forth Like a Lion. One should pay homage.

One should also hold the name of the Tathāgata of the zenith, Suvarṇaprabhāsa-śrī-abhayakara-rāja, Golden Light, Splendor, King Free from Fear. One should pay homage.

Maitreya, if a son of good family who has faith, or a daughter of good family, recites the names of these twelve Blessed Ones, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, then for ten days one should confess the faults of all one's misdeeds. One should rejoice in all roots of virtue. One should entreat all the buddhas to teach, and request all the buddhas to remain. And one should dedicate all roots of virtue by dedicating them to the dharmadhātu. By doing so, all misdeeds will be exhausted, and all karmic obscurations will be completely purified.

Thereafter one will also attain the perfection of the qualities and adornments of a buddha-field, the perfection of fearlessness, the perfection of the marks, the perfection of the community of bodhisattvas, and the perfection of dhāraṇīs. One will also attain the perfection of meditative absorptions. According to one's wish, one will swiftly gain the perfection of a completely pure buddha-field, and the perfection of virtuous spiritual friends. One will not fall away from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, nor ever be wholly diminished in it. While wandering in saṃsāra, one's lifetimes will be altogether beautiful, and one will gain perfection of wealth, perfection of lineage, perfection of birth, perfection of family, perfection of bodily form, and perfection of a retinue of like-minded people.

On this it is said:

In whatever place one is born,
in each and every lifetime,
one will be a joy to behold, and a giver of joy,
one will be radiant and of great power,
and will come to great prosperity.

One should also recite these foundations of the secret mantra of the dhāraṇī.

Tadyathā: Akhe, Makhe, Samanta-mukhe, Sautiyukte, Nirukte, Prabhe, Samayoge, Cittacitte, Akhe, Makhe, Madane, Vivarte, Samanta-guṇi, Satyārame, Yukte, Prayukte, Hili Mili, Masale, Ānale, Came, Acite, Coce, Arahe, Bahuccho, Māyugrahe, Hemavati, Jyotivati, Dharmacitte, Cyutapadke, Avikṣebe, Radhṛkṣame, Skandha-vighakte.

I pay homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. By the blessing of the buddhas, may these foundations of the secret mantra be accomplished.

On this it is said:

When these dhāraṇīs are upheld,
the sages dwelling in the ten directions,
sixty million in number,
will turn their minds toward that person.

In every birth one will also
find virtuous spiritual friends.

Whatever small virtue one has,
all one's aims will come to fruition.

Those who dwell upon the heart of a lotus,

The buddhas are seen directly.

Those who uphold these dhāraṇīs
are born spontaneously, wise and glorious.

Mindfulness, intelligence, and realization,
faith, and wisdom increase greatly.

They come to retain everything they hear,
and what they have heard never fades.

Whoever recites the names
of these Protectors of the World
abandons all the bad destinies
and swiftly goes to the happy destinies.

The supreme meditative absorptions and dhāraṇīs
become manifest to that person,
and that one will attain supreme awakening.

Though one were to give in generosity
millions upon thousands of buddha-fields
filled with gold,

the mass of merit of one who upholds
the names of the Tathāgatas
is far greater still.

One will always remember one's former lives.
While practicing the conduct of awakening,
one abandons all the unfavorable conditions,
finds the glorious arising of a buddha,
pleases the perfectly awakened buddhas,
and gains unsurpassed faith.
Having deep faith in the buddhas,
one will make supreme offerings.
Pleasing the buddhas who appear,
one sees the Teacher and has deep faith.
Having seen the Lamp of the World,
one will make excellent offerings.

Whoever upholds these names
will abandon saṃsāra
for countless millions of eons
and will swiftly attain great awakening.
If one upholds these names
for a full seven days and nights,
the vast eye by which the Guides are seen
will be purified.

Any person who upholds
the names of those Protectors of the World,
in whatever birth and wherever born,
will become worthy of homage.
Whoever upholds these names,
for inconceivable millions of eons,
will not meet with disrespect,
and will gain renown throughout the world.
For one who upholds these names,
the gods will show reverence
for many eons,
and one will swiftly attain great awakening.

Whoever upholds these names
will not lack faith, and wisdom will not be disordered.
Deceit and trickery are wholly abandoned,
and one will always see the buddhas.

Whoever upholds these names
will always be protected by gods,
gandharvas, lords of the nāgas,
garuḍas, asuras, and yakṣas.

One will be born in the home of a very wealthy person,
perfect in form and in the major marks,
giving to all sentient beings,
courageous, generous, and free of miserliness.

For hundreds of millions of eons
the fragrance of red divine sandalwood
and of every most sweet-smelling incense
will issue from that person's mouth.

Whoever upholds these names
will for millions of eons
have a voice endowed with the melody of Brahmā,
and will always be a Dharma king who lives by the Dharma.

Whoever upholds these names
will be born with a godlike form and great wealth,
from among many millions and thousands
of lotus petals made of the seven precious substances.

Whoever upholds these names
will never see separation
from father, mother, siblings, loved ones,
or the gatherings of people.

If a woman takes up the names
of the great sages,
she will not be attached to a woman's body,
and will become a man endowed with intelligence.

Having obtained a human body,
she will attain unsurpassed awakening,
turn the wheel of Dharma,
and pass beyond sorrow with desires pacified.

Whoever upholds these names,
upon that person's body
weapons, poison, fire, kings,
and deceivers will have no hold.
Whoever upholds these names,
into that person's mind
Māra, with his armies and mounts,
will never find an opening.
Whoever upholds the names of these Protectors
will travel through the sky
to inconceivable millions of buddha-fields.

Having made offerings to the teachings of the buddhas,
let them ask their questions without fear.
Knowing the thoughts of those who ask,
those Victors will give their prophecies.
Having received prophecy
from those buddhas, the Protectors,
that person will be filled with great joy
and will have no doubt about the Victor's teaching.

Those who uphold these names
will hear the profound Dharma
from the Protectors of the world,
and having heard it, will hold it all.
Then the perfections and the grounds,
the fearlessnesses and the powers,
and the excellent major and minor marks
will all be perfected without exception.

In whichever buddha-field
they wish to be born, among those buddhas,
there they will fully realize unsurpassed,
perfect awakening and become a buddha.
Whether man or woman,
whoever upholds these names,
this merit and other qualities as well
the buddhas will proclaim continuously for eons.

These buddhas are Śrīgarbha,
Meghārāja, Supreme among Humans,
and these Protectors of the world.
Whoever for an eon listens to their names,
and whoever, hearing these names,
comes to hold them in reverence,
those beings will have great wisdom
and become supreme among the two-legged.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, together with those bodhisattvas, those monks, that whole assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

It was translated and revised by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor-translator, the venerable Yeshe De. (The colophon breaks off here, in the middle of the sentence about the language.)

- The long epithets of the eastern buddha and of Peerless's future buddha-name are compounds of many elements whose Sanskrit I have reconstructed only approximately; the sequence of elements in the Tibetan is clear, but the parsing of some epithets (for instance, whether "Vairocana" stands as its own name or as part of a compound) is uncertain. The Tibetan "muktikā" (mu tig can) is rendered "Pearl-Possessing." The text breaks off after the western buddha, apparently incomplete or continuing in the next passage.
- The Sanskrit names of the twelve buddhas are reconstructed from the Tibetan and are provisional. The mantra syllables are given in the Sanskritized transliteration of the Tibetan, which appears corrupt in places (for example "Sautiyukte," "Coce," "Radhrkṣame"), so it should be recited as it stands in the transmitted text. The passage breaks off mid-verse at its end, with a sentence continuing into the next section. The phrase "ten days" for the practice follows the Tibetan འུགས་བྱེད་ཀྱི་ཡི་ཤིང་།
- The Tibetan has some corrupt or unclear readings, notably "འུགས་བྱེད་ཀྱི་ཡི་ཤིང་།"

- The names in the verse beginning "These buddhas are Śrīgarbha, Meghārāja..." are rendered as epithets from the Tibetan (dpal snying po, sprin gyi rgyal po, mi yi mchog). The line is read as a list of buddha names and epithets, not a single name, and the identification is not certain. The Tibetan text ends in mid-colophon at "skad" (language), so the colophon is left unfinished.

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.